



Mandarinfish

Synchiropus splendidus

The small, colorful mandarinfish lives on shallow lagoons and inshore reefs. It hides among dead coral during the day, but small groups gather to forage at night. A weak swimmer, it often “walks” along the bottom on its large pectoral fins. A small mouth limits its diet to small prey, such as tiny crustaceans.

The skin cells of the mandarinfish contain a blue pigment. This and one closely related species are the only fish known to produce this colored chemical. The color pattern is also a warning to predators. Its skin is coated in a protective layer of mucus. Filled with noxious chemicals, the mucus smells—and tastes—unpleasant. The slime also keeps off external parasites, which might exploit a sleeping fish.

- ↔ 3 in (6 cm)
- 🏠 Not known
- ⊗ Not known
- 🐞 Crustaceans, worms, snails
- 🏠 🌿



Indonesian Ocean

▷ PREPARING TO SPAWN

The fish remain in bodily contact as they swim up from the reef, releasing eggs and sperm into the open water.

